Maria Costa

Target user · Seller Shield

Proto-persona



"I make pottery, not paperwork. One dispute can eat my whole evening."

Age	34
Business	Ceramics shop, 14 months old
Volume	~200 orders / month, avg. €60
Team	Solo, plus a part-time packer
Stack	Shopify + PayPal checkout

Hands-on | **Busy**

Detail-proud | **Not a lawyer**

Bio

Maria sells handmade mugs and vases to buyers across Europe. Sales are growing, but as a newer seller PayPal holds some of her payouts, and every dispute lands on her alone. She doesn't know what evidence PayPal wants, misses that tracking was never added, and often refunds just to make the problem go away.

Goals

- Keep the money she has already earned
- Handle a dispute in minutes, not an evening
- Get payouts released faster

Frustrations

- Funds on hold, with no clear reason why
- Unclear evidence rules and tight deadlines
- "Not as described" claims are her word vs. the buyer's
- Missing tracking quietly voids Seller Protection

Motivations

Cash flow

Time saved

Peace of mind

Fairness in disputes

Low cost

Where she works

Shopify | PayPal | Instagram | Gmail | Phone, between orders

What she needs

An assistant that adds missing tracking, lists the evidence each case needs, and tells her whether to fight or refund, with a reply ready, so she only has to tap approve.

How I did the research

1

Listened to sellers

Read PayPal Community threads on holds, limitations and disputes. 16 verbatim seller quotes, each linked, feed the empathy map.

2

Checked the platform

PayPal developer docs: Disputes API and sandbox testing, adding tracking, Seller Protection and Chargeback Protection rules.

3

Mapped alternatives

PayPal's own tools, tracking-sync apps (Synctrack, PaySync, PalSync, AST Pro), Chargeflow and Disputifier: pricing, ratings, gaps.

4

Pressure-tested scope

Two AI agents debated the plan, one for and one against, until they agreed on a 9-day feature list and a pilot test.

What changed because of it

- Narrowed the target to small online sellers who take PayPal and handle disputes themselves
- Moved the tracking fixer from headline feature into the health scan: tracking sync is a $0–19/month commodity
- Focused the AI on one decision per dispute: fight or refund, and why, with the seller's approval
- Cut Insights, a separate Today feed and the evidence PDF from the 9-day build
- Built it and tested it: the app gave the expected answer on all 21 test cases (my rules decide 17, the AI 4), in 4 out of 4 runs

Main persona: Maria Costa



Maria Costa

“I make pottery, not paperwork. One dispute can eat my whole evening.”

Age: 34

Occupation: Founder of an online ceramics shop (14 months)

Education: BA in Fine Arts*

Location: Porto, sells across Europe

Status: Solo seller; PayPal holds part of her payouts

Interests

- Ceramics and handmade craft
- Growing her shop on Instagram
- Small-business tips
- Craft fairs and markets*

Goals

- Keep the money she has earned
- Handle a dispute in minutes
- Get payouts released faster
- Make the shop her full-time income*

Pain Points / Frustrations

- Funds on hold with no clear reason
- Unclear evidence rules, tight deadlines
- “Not as described” = her word vs. the buyer’s
- Refunds just to make it go away

Motivations

- Cash flow keeps the studio running
- Time back for making, not admin
- Fair treatment as an honest seller

Challenges

- Missing tracking voids Seller Protection
- Policies are long and legalistic
- No team, lawyer or accountant
- Fragile items get damaged in transit

Needs & Expectations

- “Fight or refund?” with a clear reason
- Evidence pack ready; she just approves
- Deadline alerts on her phone
- Nothing sent without her OK

Technology & Social Media

- Phone-first, laptop for admin
- Daily: Instagram, Shopify app, Gmail
- Often: PayPal app, WhatsApp, Pinterest*
- ChatGPT for product descriptions*

Content-Type Preferences

- Checklists and step-by-step guides
- Short how-to videos and Reels
- Peer stories from seller forums
- Quick answers over long policy pages

Brands & Influences

- Shopify, PayPal, Etsy
- PayPal Community and eBay forums
- r/smallbusiness, r/Etsy*
- Maker accounts on Instagram*

** Assumption: validate with seller interviews. Name, location and numbers are illustrative; portrait is AI-generated.*

Empathy map: Maria Costa

Says

“My first order comes through and PayPal locks down my account and freezes the funds. $30.” PayPal Community

“Paypal found the dispute in the buyers favour and will offer them a refund.” PayPal Community

“So to be clear, the customer now has the product and the money” PayPal Community

“They are now holding money that was supposed to be paid to my suppliers” PayPal Community



Thinks

“how can Paypal guarantee me?” PayPal Community

“why do they always favour the buyer, without proper proof” PayPal Community

“Who plays with my funds and earns on that? Not me!!!” PayPal Community

“I have no faith in being a customer with PayPal if this can happen with just one dispute.” PayPal Community

Does

Adds tracking, still waits: “Regarding my last sale I provided tracking number” PayPal Community

Sends all the proof: “I provided everything to PayPal.” PayPal Community

Chases support: “I spoke with several people at PayPal over the course of several weeks” PayPal Community

Waits for a review: “ive already submitted a resolution but its almost a year nothing happened” PayPal Community

Feels

Frustrated: “I am seriously frustrated with Paypal,” PayPal Community

Helpless: “I feel helpless as I am not receiving any support from PayPal.” PayPal Community

Afraid: “I'm afraid in the case that the buyer refunds while the item is in transit” PayPal Community

Fed up: “I am leaving PayPal for good.” PayPal Community

How it was built: Every note is a verbatim quote from a seller on the PayPal Community forum, linked to its thread (accessed 3 Nov 2026), grouped into the four quadrants. Labels in bold are my summary. Maria is a composite of these sellers, not one person.

Persona use cases in detail



Maria Costa

Independent ceramics seller

Age: 34

Occupation: Shop founder (14 months)

Education: BA in Fine Arts*

Location: Porto, sells across Europe

Status: Solo seller, payouts on hold

Dispute Triage: **Built: open cases first, with deadlines**
I want all open disputes in one list, ranked by money at risk and deadline, so that I always handle the most urgent case first.

Evidence Pack: **Partly built: evidence checklist, tracking sent as proof**
I want the app to gather tracking, the product listing, buyer messages and my policies into a ready evidence pack, so that I can respond in minutes without knowing PayPal's rules by heart.

Fight-or-Refund Advice: **Built, without a win chance (the app never predicts)**
I want a clear recommendation with a plain-English reason and an estimated win chance, so that I only fight the disputes that are worth fighting.

Missing Tracking Fixer: **Built (sandbox)**
I want missing tracking added to my PayPal transactions in one tap, so that my orders qualify for Seller Protection and held payouts are released sooner.

Deadline Alerts: **Partly built: warnings in the app, no phone alert**
I want a phone alert before every dispute deadline, so that I never lose a case by default.

Prevention Insights: **Later**
I want to see which products and shipping habits lead to disputes, so that I can fix listings and prevent the next claim.

Pain points for the top 3 use cases



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Independent ceramics seller

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Location: Porto, sells across Europe

Status: Solo seller, payouts on hold

Evidence Pack:

I can't respond to a dispute with confidence because I don't know what evidence PayPal expects for each type of claim, so I lose an evening guessing, or miss the deadline and lose by default.

Seller on the forum: “why do they always favour the buyer, without proper proof” PayPal Community

Fight-or-Refund Advice:

I can't tell whether a dispute is worth fighting because a “not as described” claim is my word against the buyer's, so I often refund just to make it go away and lose the payment, the item and the fees.

Forum reply to a seller: “it is always one persons word against anothers.” PayPal Community

Missing Tracking Fixer:

I can't keep my orders protected because tracking isn't always attached to the PayPal transaction, which quietly removes Seller Protection and keeps my payouts on hold for longer.

Seller on the forum: “I don't want to wait 21 days or more for MY MONEY.” PayPal Community

Competitor analysis: who already solves Maria's problems

Who	Price	Tracking → PayPal	PayPal disputes	Tells her: fight or refund, and why	Built for
PayPal today The platform Seller Shield builds on: Resolution Center, Seller Protection	Free; Chargeback Protection is a paid add-on	× Seller adds it by hand	~ She answers each case herself	× No guidance	~ Every seller, do-it-yourself
Tracking-sync apps Synctrack, PaySync, PalSync, AST Pro (Woo)	$0–19 / month (PaySync)	✓ Automatic on fulfilment	~ PaySync $19 plan: dispute dashboard	× No	✓ Small stores
Chargeflow AI dispute automation, 20,000+ brands	25% of each recovered chargeback	× Not offered	✓ Automated incl. PayPal	~ Win-odds score; auto-submits	~ High-volume stores
Disputifier AI chargeback fighting on Shopify	20% of won revenue; alerts $17–27.50 each	× Not offered	~ PayPal listed; fighting unclear	~ AI auto-responses	~ Shopify merchants
Seller Shield Health scan + tracking fixer + guided case	**Flat €15–19 / month (planned, to test)**	✓ Bulk push + finds the gaps	✓ Guided case, she approves	✓ Plain-English reason + eligibility	✓ Small, owner-run shops

Sources: PaySync · Synctrack · AST Pro (Woo) · Chargeflow / pricing (via Redo) · Disputifier · PayPal Chargeback Protection. Checked 3 Nov 2026; prices change. Seller Shield price is a hypothesis for the pilot.

What the competition tells me

1

Tracking sync alone is a commodity

Several apps already push tracking to PayPal for $0–19 a month, and Shopify doesn't do it natively. Selling tracking on its own means competing on price.

So: keep the tracking fixer, but as part of the health scan, not as the headline.

2

Dispute tools are built for volume

Chargeflow (25%) and Disputifier (20%) take a cut of what they recover and submit automatically. They're aimed at stores with many chargebacks, not one or two €60 claims a month.

So: the gap is the decision, not the automation. “Fight or refund, and why?” with her approval.

3

PayPal's own cover has holes

Chargeback Protection covers only card payments through Advanced checkout, and only “unauthorized” and “item not received” chargebacks.

So: “not as described” cases and everyday PayPal disputes are where Maria is alone.

Research changed my plan: the tracking fixer moved from headline feature into the health scan, and the AI now focuses on one decision per dispute.

Positioning

For small sellers who take PayPal, Seller Shield protects every order and tells you, in plain English, whether a dispute is worth fighting, at a flat price, and nothing is sent without your OK.

Problem Statement

Based on the biggest pain point for my persona, a concise hypothesis.

PROBLEM

Small online sellers who take PayPal lose money and evenings to payment holds and disputes. Tracking often isn't attached to their PayPal orders, and every “not as described” claim feels like their word against the buyer's.

SOLUTION

Seller Shield scans their PayPal account, adds missing tracking in one go, and turns each dispute into a plain-English “fight or refund” recommendation with a ready response they approve.

IMPACT

I expect at least half of pilot sellers to protect their flagged orders in their first session, and 40% to say they'd be “very disappointed” without it.

Mission

Based on the hypothesis and solution, one simple sentence with the high-level goal.

MISSION

We make it easy for small sellers who take PayPal **to keep the money they've earned** and settle disputes in minutes, not evenings.

“I make pottery, not paperwork.” — Maria, my persona

Prioritize into a roadmap with the RICE model

Score = R × I × C ÷ E

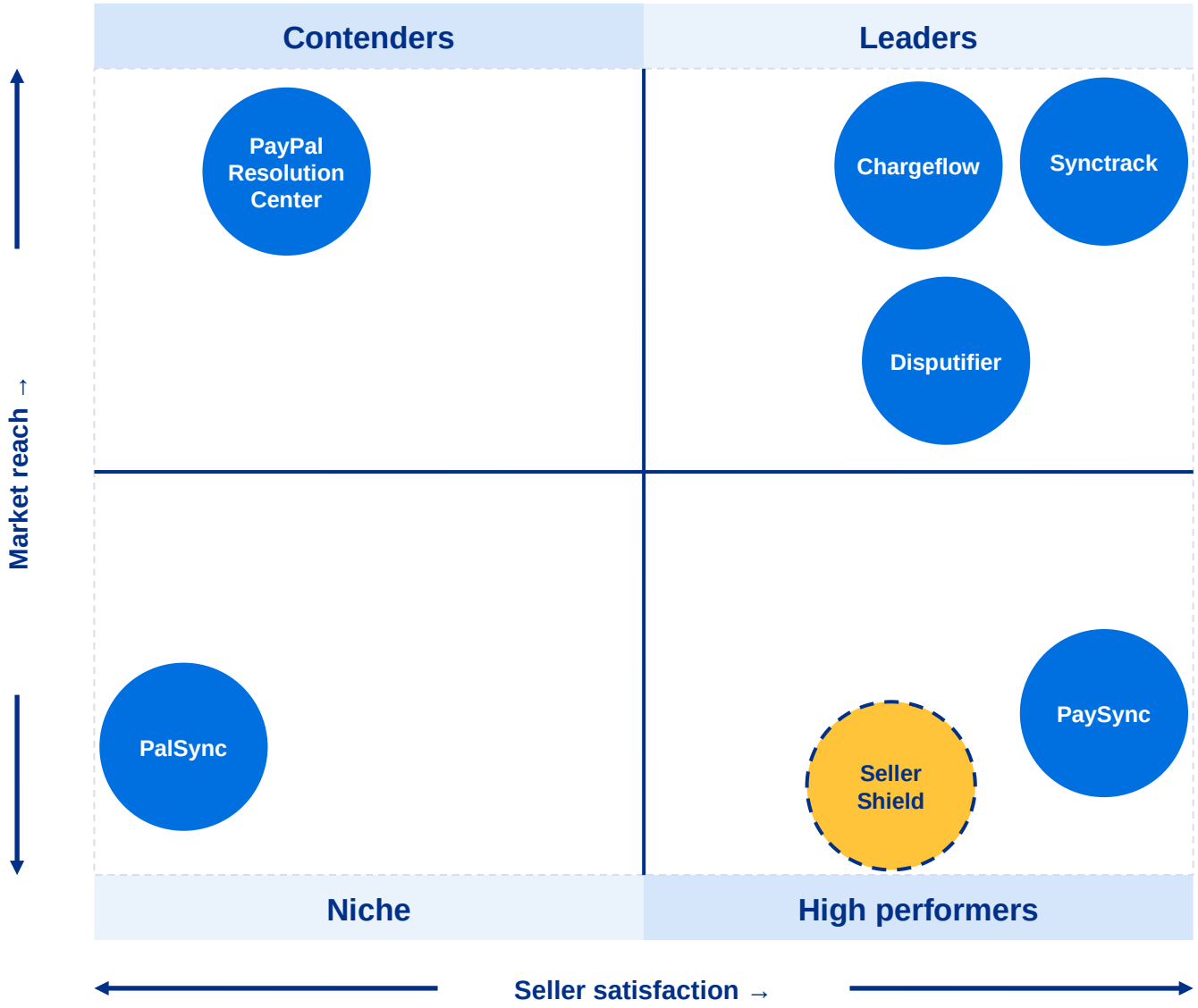
Feature	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort (days)	Score	Status, 9 Nov
Tracking fixer AG Grid table, bulk add to PayPal	12	7	5	2	**210**	**Built**
Health scan Money held, missing tracking, deadlines	15	5	4	1.5	**200**	**Built**
Deadline alerts Email before a dispute is due	7	5	4	1	**140**	**In-app warnings; email cut**
Evidence PDF One-click evidence pack	7	3	4	1	**84**	**Next**
AI dispute case Fight or refund, why, draft, approve	7	9	3	4	**47**	**Built***
Prevention insights Patterns that cause disputes	3	4	2	2	**12**	**Later**

Scoring: Reach = sellers (of 15 in the pilot) who'd use it in a month; ~45% get at least one dispute a month. Impact 1–10. Confidence = evidence it matters, capped at 5 until I have user data. Effort = days of my 9-day build, including technical risk. All estimates, before the pilot.

Reading it: the tracking fixer ranks first: it has the strongest evidence (confirmed delivery releases holds) and reaches most sellers. ***The AI dispute case scores low but is in the build as a stated bet:** no competitor offers it to small sellers, and it's the core PayPal + AI use the judges score.

Appendix: Competitive Analysis

Seller Shield (target) Competitors



How each one is placed

Synctrack: 5.0★ · 451 reviews
Chargeflow: 4.5★ · 436 reviews
Disputifier: 4.6★ · 137 reviews
PaySync: 5.0★ · 4 reviews
PalSync: 3.1★ · 3 reviews
PayPal today: every seller has it; placed by judgement
Seller Shield: pre-launch, plotted at its goal

Reach = Shopify App Store review count (log scale). Satisfaction = app rating. PayPal's spot is a judgement from the forum quotes, not a score.

Reading it

Leaders do one job: tracking or chargebacks. The gap is bottom-right: small sellers who want guidance on PayPal disputes and are happy with it. That's where Seller Shield aims to start.